



Keeping Your PC Trim And Proper

Every Windows XP PC gets sluggish over a period of time. Give it some TLC to regain lost speed!

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A Windows XP computer... is much like a car. It requires maintenance to keep it running smoothly. It needs to be well-oiled, so to speak, using the methods we'll mention. Some of these might be familiar, but you're to find something you didn't know about before!

Organise Files And Folders

XP usually stores most of your files in the My Documents folder, which resides on the C drive. You should relocate this folder to another drive such as D, so that your data remains intact when you reinstall Windows. To do this, create a folder such as "MyDocs" on the D drive, right-click on My Documents, click on Properties, enter D:\MyDocs in the Target box, and click OK. You will be asked whether you wish to move all the documents from the old location to the new location; click Yes.

You could then create folders such as Work, Home, etc., in My Documents. Windows already has a good way of organising files—there is My Pictures to store images, My Music to store music

and so on, but you can create additional folders inside these to categorise your pictures, music, etc. so it becomes easy to locate them. If you need to search and want to do it faster, install an indexing and search tool—such as Windows Desktop Search, Google Desktop Search, or Copernicus Desktop Search. These index your files for faster retrieval.

You should also relocate your default Outlook mail and address book store folder to the D (or any other) drive. Open the Registry Editor and go to the appropriate key according to the version of Outlook. If you're using Outlook 2003, locate the key [HKEY_CURRENT_USER\Software\Microsoft\Office\11.0\Outlook]. For Outlook XP, replace

"11.0" with "10.0"; for Outlook 2000, it's "9.0". Create an Expandable String Value (REG_EXPAND_SZ) called ForcePSTPath, and set it to equal the full path of the required personal folder directory such as D:\MyMail (you need to create this destination beforehand). Exit the Registry and log out of Windows for the change to take effect.

If you use Outlook Express, this is simpler: go to Tools > Options > Maintenance > Store Folder and click Change.... Point to the new location.

Delete Or Compress Files

You can do this using the Disk Cleanup tool. To launch it, go to Start > All Programs > Accessories > System Tools > Disk Cleanup. Use this tool to clean up each of your drives and compress infrequently used files and folders. Some temporary files will still be left in the temporary folders; manually delete these by opening the folders %temp% and C:\Windows\Temp. You can access the former by typing it into the Run dialog box.

As you surf the Internet and your browser downloads pages, it stores them as temporary files. This is to make surfing faster: for example, when you click the Back button, the browser need not download the previous page again—it loads it from the cache containing the temporary files. After a longish while, though, say a month, these are likely to be of no use. Delete the temporary Internet files this way: in Internet Explorer, go to Tools > Internet Options. Under the Temporary Internet files section, click Delete Files. Check the box in front of Delete all offline content and click OK. If you use Opera, select Tools > Preferences, go to the Advanced tab, click on History, and click Empty now. Firefox users need to select Tools > Options, go to the Cache tab, and click Clear Cache Now.

To minimise the space occupied by mails, in Outlook, click on Tools > Options > Mail Setup. Click the Data Files button, select Archive Folders from the list, click

Settings, and click Compact Now. This will compress that particular folder; do the same for all the items in the list. If you use Outlook Express, select File > Folder > Compact All to achieve the same thing.

Defragment

Files get scattered all over the hard drive, so accessing them becomes slower. This tends to increase over time as more and more programs are installed. The Disk Defragmenter bundled with Windows organises files on your hard drive, thus helping it run more efficiently. If you have a highly-fragmented drive, this will make a huge difference to the performance of your PC. Go to Start > All Programs > Accessories > System Tools > Disk Defragmenter. Select a drive and click Defragment, and do that for all your drives. Whether or not the program advises you to defragment a drive or not, you should defragment once a month.

Speed Up XP Boot-up

One of the main causes of XP booting slowly is the method of loading drivers. Windows versions prior to XP loaded drivers sequentially, but since XP, it has been done concurrently, causing a slowdown. This information is written to the file C:\WINDOWS\Prefetch\Layout.ini. While creating this file, XP does a partial defragmentation of the files listed in Layout.ini to make them available in one contiguous area of the hard drive, allowing to load them faster. Various factors adversely affect this defragmentation process, such as a fragmented hard drive, improper defragmentation of the above files by the regular Defragmenter, etc. It is therefore necessary to do this defragmentation manually using a utility from Microsoft known as BootVis, available at <http://www.majorgeeks.com/download.php?det=664>. Extract the ZIP file and run BootVis.exe (very preferably after defragmenting your hard disk).

The first step in tweaking or troubleshooting your boot process is to run a boot trace. Go to File > New > Next Boot + Drivers Trace. The Trace Repetitions window will prompt you for the number of repetitions (reboots and traces) to run. Let's go with the defaults; click OK. BootVis Cancel the reboot if you need to save your work, then reboot.

After XP reboots, BootVis restarts automatically and provides individual graphs for the system activity areas such



Windows desktop search



Compress your Outlook mail folder